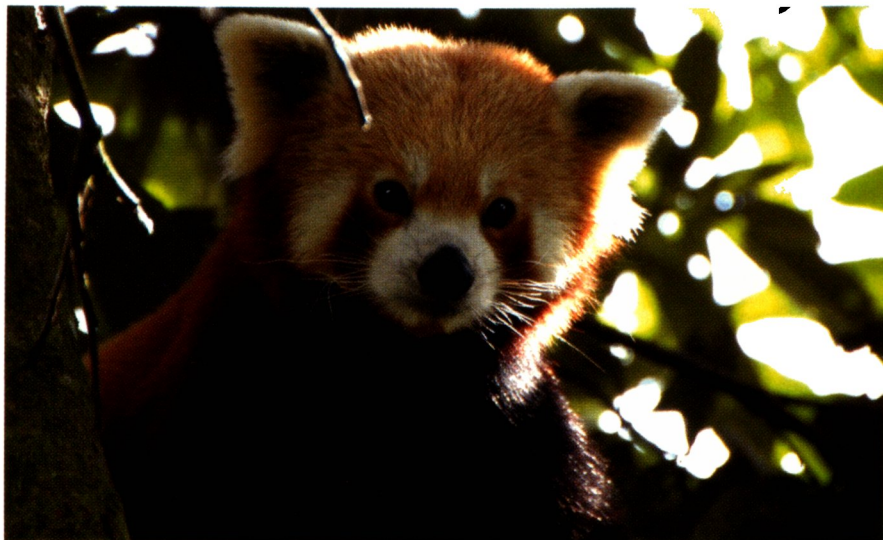


the people of the state. This has resulted in the Centre according national recognition to the Sikkimese and the more the State tops national rankings, the more does the rest of nation start noticing and recognizing it. Some years back, former Rajya Sabha MP from Sikkim Karma Topden became the first person from Sikkim to be appointed Ambassador and served the country in Mongolia. Footballer Baichung Bhutia is already a household name and now also the recipient of the Arjuna Award. And then there is Sikkim's export to the tinsel world, Danny Denzongpa, who was honoured with a Padmashree in 2003. The first Chief Minister of Sikkim, Kazi Lhendup Dorji Khangsarpa, who passed away recently in July 2007, was honoured with the Padma Vibhushan in 2005. Sikkimese writers have also started receiving recognition from the Sahitya Akademi and when AP Subba was elevated to the post of a High Court judge a couple of years back, he became the first person from Sikkim to reach so high in the judiciary. Tourism has been aggressively promoted and as more and more domestic tourists check into Sikkim, the nation's love affair with the Himalayan State grows stronger. The process of assimilation with the national mainstream has well and truly begun.

Top priority to healthcare

The SDF Government has accorded top priority to the health sector. As a result of which infant mortality rate has sharply decreased to 33 per thousand against 46 in 1994, which is the ninth lowest in the country. More emphasis is being laid upon preventive aspect of health management. The Government's sincere efforts in this sector were vindicated when Sikkim topped the rank of Best Performing State in the field of primary health at the India Today held, 2005 State of the States conclave.

Health services are free in the State and most of the Health Indices are better than the National Average. Sikkim became the first state in the country to launch Hepatitis – B vaccination free of cost to the children aged below five years. A 500 bedded Central Referral Hospital has been constructed at Tadong. Modernization and upgradation of Sikkim's premier STNM Hospital in Gangtok, District Hospitals, PHCs and PHSCs throughout the State have been initiated. Referral cum financial assistance to patients requiring treatment outside the state is provided. Regular healthcamps are conducted through specialists from renowned hospitals of the country and abroad. Besides providing free treatment to the people, the Government believes in the dictum 'Prevention is better than cure' and encourages activities which affect the consciousness of the people and encourages them towards cleanliness.



A GREAT LEAP FORWARD

Key Indicators	Units	2006-07	1993-94
Per capita income (at current price)	Rs.	29,808	9,350
GSDP (at current price)	Rs. in Crores	1531	337
Infant Mortality Rate	per'000	32	46
Literacy Rate	%	82	56
Child Immunisation	%	91.6	-
Birth Rate	per'000	19.5	24.6
Daily Wages	Rs.	100	20
Forest Cover	%	45.97	43.95
Milk Production	Lakh Litres	39	16
Domestic Tourists	Numbers	2,92,486	70,365
Foreign Tourists	Numbers	18,026	7,360
Power Production	MU	165.00	65.81
Consumer Co-operatives	Numbers	574	253
People below poverty line	%	19.2	41.43
Annual Plan 2007-08	Rs. in Crores	689.17	120.00
Annual State Revenue 2005-06	Rs. in Crores	261.14	41.30

An oasis of peace

In times when Border States grapple with problems of crime and extremism, Sikkim remains an oasis of peace. The only State of the nation to share international boundaries with three countries [China to the North, Nepal to the West and Bhutan to the East and separated from Bangladesh by a narrow corridor], the State has none of the usual problems that confound other border regions. There are no extremist groups here, neither is smuggling a worry, nor trafficking. In fact, Sikkim has taken the lead in re-introducing borders as regions of amiability rather than points of conflict. While the border with Tibet

Autonomous Region of China has been opened at Nathula for trade between the two countries; the western front with Nepal is a popular trekking destination. Effort has been taken to see that not only does peace prevail on its international borders but also among the local ethnic groups, including Nepalais, Lepchas and Bhutias.

The Chief Minister's vision of creating a peaceful pluralistic polity has made tremendous achievements in ensuring a good quality of life for its people. Sikkim has the unparalleled distinction of being a state with a very high degree of political stability, a well-established example of social harmony, peace and tranquility. National Crime Research Bureau, New Delhi shows that Sikkim has the lowest number of Number of cases Registered under IPC. The latest report of the Institute for Conflict Management, New Delhi showed that Sikkim is one state in the country where there is no insurgency and conflict. This is proved by the declaration of Union Home minister who said 'Sikkim is the most peaceful state of the nation'. This low crime rate is a tribute to the inherently law-abiding nature of the people as well as the professionalism of its law enforcing agencies, guided by the vision of the State Government.